NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣J

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠5

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K Q J ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ J 8 6 4 ♣ K Q	
♠ 10 8 5 ♥ 3 ♦ K 10 9 2 ♣ 7 6 5 4 2		♠ 9 6 3 ♥ A 10 9 8 ♦ A Q 5 ♣ J 10 9
	♠ 7 4 2 ♥ K Q J 6 5 ♦ 7 3 ♣ A 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	3NT
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♣J

which holds the trick.

Partner's 2♦ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

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Partner tells you that he has enough points to be in game, and that he holds exactly 5 ♥s. With your 3 ♥s you know of an 8-card Major fit so you correct the contract to 4♥.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣J. You win the opening lead with your ♣Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

The 2 ♦ losers are unavoidable, and even you will have to give up a trick to the Ace of trumps. So you have to make sure not to lose a second ♥.

Win the ♣Q and play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥J,

I hope you didn't continue drawing trumps by playing the ♥K. If you did then you are going down in an ice-cold contract.

The way to lose only one ♥ trick is to keep leading toward dummy's honors. So come to your hand with a black card and play another ♥ in that direction, leading through East's ♥A. When you win that trick repeat the maneuver.

It is really against the odds for East to hold ♥ A 10 9 x. In fact it would only occur perhaps one time in seven.

But there is no reason to go down once every seven times when you don't need to.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 10 9 2
♥ Q 7 3
♦ 9 8 7
♣ K 9 6 2

♠ A K J 5
♥ A J 10 5
♦ A 6 4
♣ 8 3



♠ Q 4
♥ K 8 6 2
♦ K Q J 3
♣ A 7 5

♠ 8 7 6 3
♥ 9 4
♦ 10 5 2
♣ Q J 10 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♥	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♣Q

The 2♣ bid was Stayman, so you bid your ♥s.

Partner takes the direct approach and puts you in slam.

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♣Q. South finds their best lead, exposing your ♣ loser right off the bat.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

If you can guess the ♥ finesse correctly you will make 7, discarding dummy's ♣ loser on the fourth ♦. But if you guess wrong they will immediately set you with a ♣ trick.

There is a better way - one that combines two chances. Win the ♣A. Then play your ♥A and ♥K. If the ♥Q happens to fall, pull the last trump and run your winners.

If the ♥Q **DOESN'T** fall, (she won't of course), switch to ♦s. On the fourth round of ♦s discard dummy's ♣, whether it is ruffed with the ♥Q or not.

If you knew to play the North for the ♥Q then you wouldn't need this improved plan.

But playing the deal as described will win whenever the ♥Q is doubleton, **OR** when the player with the protected ♥Q holds at least 3 ♦s.

Pretty good odds, better than the going rate for finesses, which is 50% off.

There was an alternate plan, just as good. After taking the two top trumps, run the ♠s, discarding two ♣s from your hand. As you see, either would have worked.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 6 2
♥ A 10 9
♦ 10 6 5
♣ K Q 7 6 4

♠ A 10 8 5 3
♥ K 5
♦ 8 7 4 3
♣ 9 3



♠ K 9 7
♥ 8 7 6 4 2
♦ A 9
♣ 10 8 2

♠ Q J 4
♥ Q J 3
♦ K Q J 2
♣ A J 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠5

Partner's 2NT bid invites you to bid game if you have a maximum hand. You aren't thrilled by all the Quacks in your hand but with 17 points you bid 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠5. East wins the first trick with the ♠K and returns the ♠9. West plays the ♠3 under your ♠J.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 5 :: Total = 7

You need 2 more tricks, and the ♦ suit will provide them after you drive out the ♦A.

Is that what you should do?

That is definitely **NOT** what you should do. West led the ♠5, then played the ♠3 to the second trick. You have seen the ♠4 and ♠2 so it is clear that West started with a 5-card suit. That means East still has a ♠. The instant you play a ♦ one of the defenders will grab the ♦A and West will take his three more ♠ tricks.

As much as you hate to put your contract in the hands of a 50% finesse chance, that is what you must do. Forget the ♦ suit and finesse West for the ♥K, trying for two extra tricks in ♥s.

West played very well to duck the second ♠, leaving his partner with a ♠ in case he could get the lead.

So you have to play well and stay away from ♦s.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q J 10 6 ♥ 6 ♦ K 8 5 4 2 ♣ Q 9 3	
♠ 7 ♥ K Q J 9 8 7 5 ♦ A ♣ A 8 4 2	N W E S	♠ A K 5 4 ♥ A 3 2 ♦ Q J 10 ♣ J 7 6
	♠ 9 8 3 2 ♥ 10 4 ♦ 9 7 6 3 ♣ K 10 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
4♣	Pass	4♠	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by West
Lead: ♠Q

There would be nothing wrong with a transfer bid here, but probably no advantage either. What you really want to know is how many Aces partner has. So you ask him with a Gerber 4♣ bid.

Partner says 4♠ (2 Aces),

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Partner says 4♠ (2 Aces),

Looking at three possible ♣ losers you bid 6♥.

West plays 6♥. North leads the ♠Q. The first trick is easy; you win with dummy's ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 3

It can't do any good to ruff your fourth ♣ in dummy because you would have to lose two before that could happen. Of course one of your ♣s can be discarded on dummy's ♠K but what about the other two?

Suppose you win the ♠ and unblock the ♦A. Play ♥K, then to dummy's ♥A. Take one ♣ discard on the ♠K, then play the ♦Q and discard a second ♣.

It won't work. You would establish the ♦ for your last discard but you have no entry to it.

This will work. At trick 2 discard the ♦A on dummy's ♠K. Play the ♦Q and discard a ♣ when South doesn't cover. North will take the ♦K and attack ♣s but you are in control now. You win your ♣A, pull trumps, ending in dummy, and discard the remaining 2 ♣ losers on dummy's ♦ J 10.

This is called a Jettison play. You sacrifice your ♦A to unblock the suit for dummy's ♦ Q J 10.

If South held the ♦K the play would be slightly different; you would have to ruff when he covered. But the result would be the same.

Did you notice that you started with 3 ♣ losers and no ♦ loser, but you ended up losing 1 ♦ and no ♣s?

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K 9 2 ♥ A 8 7 4 ♦ K 4 2 ♣ J 10	
♠ 10 7 6 5 ♥ J 10 6 2 ♦ 8 ♣ A 8 4 2	N W E S	♠ Q J ♥ K Q 3 ♦ Q J 10 9 6 5 ♣ 7 6
	♠ 8 4 3 ♥ 9 5 ♦ A 7 3 ♣ K Q 9 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♦	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♦Q

Partner's 2NT is the lebensohl convention. He requests that you bid 3♣ as a relay, which you do. Partner now bids 3NT.

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When partner bids 3NT AFTER the lebensohl 2NT, he is suggesting you play there, and he guarantees a stopper in their suit. You are happy to pass.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♦Q. East attacks in ♦s and you must make an immediate choice. Hold up, win in dummy, or win in your hand.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 5

First decide about what to do at trick #1. If you hold up and East plays another ♦, no harm will be done. But probably no good will be done either because East is likely to have 6 ♦s, leaving West with just a singleton anyway. But what if East pockets the one ♦ trick and switches to ♥s, a suit where you only have one stopper? Since that might turn out badly, you should **NOT** hold up.

As to which hand to win it in, that's easy. You need to preserve any dummy entries that you can so you win the first trick with your ♦K.

Now you establish some ♣ winners. You play the ♣J and both defenders play low.

You have to assume that defenders good enough to hold up their ♣A at the first opportunity will be good enough to do it on the second play also. But you can thwart them by next playing your ♣10 and overtaking with dummy's ♣Q. Even if they do hold up again you can continue with another ♣ from dummy to establish the suit while you still have the ♦A for an entry.

If you fail to overtake the second ♣ West will hold up the ♣A again.

Then you will lose all those ♣ tricks in dummy.